

The Gloaming Ballad of Fenspire and the Cinder Shrike

Come, draw the shutters, hush the flame, Let no bright tongue inquire; Sing low the name that watches still: The stern and stark Fenspire.

Within the Gloaming Reach it stands, Where dimness veils the land; A stark spire climbs above the gloom, As if by iron hand.

It was founded in **57 AS**, When dust lay thick and gray; And still its stones remember watch At ending of the day.

A core location, grimly held, It bears garrisoned status; **3,742** keep the walls, And none may call them stratus.

No—sing it plain, lest sleep make sport: **3,742** stand. The garrison is not a boast, But duty, blade, and brand.

Its air is shaped by occupation, Permanent, severe; Disciplined vigilance fills the stones, And keeps the dark in fear.

Yet fear has wings that make no cry, And ash upon its breast; Beyond the torch, beneath the eaves, The waiting thing is pressed.

The Cinder Shrike, of extreme threat, Moves where the night is deep; A nocturnal ambusher, still, It stalks the edge of sleep.

Its silhouette is shrike-like, lean, Blackened by soot and cinder; Its ember-dusted aspect glows Where dying sparks still glimmer.

It does not warn, it does not call, It does not stir the bough; Silent and watchful, it abides— Remember silence now.

Then sudden as a struck bell's peal, Though no bell sounds its toll, It breaks from darkness, swift and near, And violence takes the whole.

Surprise is sewn into its wing, Darkness attends its flight; The bravest oath grows thin and pale When day is swallowed night.

So Fenspire keeps its disciplined watch, Its stark spire cleaving dim; And the Cinder Shrike keeps counsel close— No hymn is safe from him.

But do not say the stone has fled, Nor claim the ash has won; The walls remain beneath the Reach, The black wing waits till sun.

Sing of the place, and sing the thing, Yet bind your song with care: For Fenspire is vigilance made, And night has eyes to spare.

When morning pales the Gloaming Reach, The spire still crowns the gray; But mark the soot beside the path— And do not linger on your way.